

MGT489 - Brand Management
EXECUTIVE MBA PROGRAM
SUMMER 2025

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OFFICE HOURS: Monday 7pm-9pm on Discord or by appointment

DESCRIPTION

A brand is often a company's most important asset and as such has received immense attention in recent years. Effective brand-building and brand management drives superior financial results, consumer loyalty and competitive advantage. This is a course with a decided point-of-view on the nature of brands and the skills and tasks this requires of managers. We will consider brands as co-creations of consumers and marketers. If brand management is a collaborative process of meaning management, the job of the brand manager then becomes one of navigating the meaning making processes, attaining meanings that resonate therein, and to managing these meanings deftly through time so as to maximize brand value, capture opportunities, and diminish risk. Some of a firm's most valuable assets are the brands that it has invested in and developed over time. Although manufacturing processes can often be duplicated, strongly held beliefs and attitudes established in consumers' minds cannot.

This is a case-based course. Cases, as microcosms of brand management, deliver the power of real-world, applied settings and reveal concepts and frameworks that can inform management thoughts and actions. Our collective experience and expertise outweighs and overshadows the knowledge any one faculty member can impart. Case discussions, and the full participation they require, is an integral component of this course.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of Topics in Marketing: Brand Management you will be able to:

- Understand what makes a strong brand.
- Identify and develop the key elements in crafting a brand strategy.
- Analyze scenarios to gain insights into how to manage your brand and expand your business.
- Understand and integrate social media's role in modern branding strategy.

MATERIALS

Required

- Case and Reading Packet.

Recommended

- _____ Kevin Lane Keller (2013), Strategic Brand Management (3rd or 4th edition). NJ: Prentice Hall. ISBN 978-0-13-2664257

2025 Hybrid Schedule

Module	EMBA Due Date	Topic(s)	Reading(s)*	Assignment
BRANDING BASICS				
1	7/6	What is a Brand?	Perspectives on Brand Equity <i>Basic Facts: Trademarks Patents and Copyrights</i>	What is your Brand - C
IN PERSON 2	7/12	Brand Equity and Architecture	Why You Aren't Buying Venezuelan Chocolate Brand Portfolio Strategy Case: Amul Dairy	Discussion Quiz – G FORM PROJECT GROUPS
3	7/20	Brand Components and Component Branding	Why Text-to-Image AI Requires a New Branding Mindset 3 Questions to Ask about Your Brand Case: Inside Intel Inside	Component Construction Group Brand Due
BRAND GROWTH & POSITIONING				
4	7/27	Brand Extensions Lifestyle Brands	Extend Profits, Not Product Lines Case: Trouble Brews at Starbucks	Brand Positioning and Gap Analysis – C
5	8/3	Brand Life Cycle: Extending and Revitalizing the Brand	Break Free of the Product Life Cycle But is it Good? Case: Does Mattel's Iconic Barbie Doll Need a Makeover? (Case not to prepare: Dove)	Brand Word Cloud - G
IN PERSON 6	8/9	Brand Story	Brand Storytelling <i>The Vodka Proof</i> Case: Tito's Handmade Vodka – The Perils of Success Case: Brand Storytelling at Shinola	Participation – C Discussion Quiz – G 6 Word Stories – C
BRAND EVOLUTION				
7	8/17	Leveraging that Equity – Brand Licensing	Think Differently About Protecting Your Brand Three Trends Shaping the Future of Brand Licensing Case: Navigating a Sea of Golf Sponsorships Case: Off-White	
8	8/24	Brands in Crisis	Lessons learned from Bud Light one year later Case: Bud Light Boycott: How the King of Beers Lost its Throne Case: McDonald's India:	Brand Report Card
9	8/31	Luxury Branding	Luxury Branding and the Creator Economy The Fundamentals of Luxury Branding Luxury Marketing: A Deep Dive into High-End Branding The Rise of Luxury Brands of Everything	Luxury Pricing Curve Estimation
IN PERSON 10	9/6	Crafting the Brand	Review Final Exam In-class cases	Final Exam

* Readings in *italics* are videos or podcasts.

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ASSIGNMENTS & DELIVERABLES

Grading

The class is made up of both group and individual assignments and exercises. On the grading sheet below, you will see the level of collaboration allowed for each assignment and graded item.

I – Independent, individual work only. No collaboration or consultation allowed.

C – Collaboration with classmates is allowed. However, each student must submit a deliverable.

G – Students may work together in groups and turn in one deliverable for the entire group.]

Deliverables	Points
Participation/Discussion Boards (I) – 10 @ 4 points	40
Assignments (C) - 10 @ 4 points	40
Final Exam	20
Total	100

Grading is done on the following scale: A [95,100]; A- [90,95]; B+ [87,90]; B [83,87]; B- [80,83]; C+ [77,80]; C [73,77]; C- [70,73]; F [0,70)

Class Participation (C)

Class participation is earned by “attending” class by contributing your thoughts and questions to the various discussions in class. In practice, great ideas that are not articulated (or are not articulated in a compelling way) are ignored. Thus, participation is important to your continued professional development. Further, much of the value of an MBA comes from the interchange with classmates who come from various industries and strategic contexts. The benefits that each of you receive from this class will be directly enhanced by the mutual sharing of insights. Thus, throughout the term, I will track the degree to which you contribute to discussion. Please know that quality of contribution (meaningful insights that help us progress in our discussion of the topic) far outweighs quantity.

In online weeks, discussion takes place on our Discord channel. In those weeks, I will post a series of questions related to the readings and case study that I would like you to explore. Each student is responsible for a) posting a **detailed** response to one of the questions or b) posting a critical and thoughtful reply to one of your fellow students' responses.

Experiential Assignments (C/G)

You will be asked to recognize, apply, and explore the branding strategies discussed in the readings and the cases. To solidify the knowledge, you will complete group discussion assignments that will ask you to do deeper analysis or take managerial stances and think deeper about the readings. These are not meant to explicitly test whether you have read that week's readings, but to answer the questions fully, understanding the weekly readings is necessary. Therefore, when completing these assignments you should use your notes and class materials. You should not use the wider internet unless specifically noted. We want you to learn and be able to apply this knowledge; LLMs already know this stuff. Hopefully, these quizzes will keep you “on task” by solidifying the knowledge and keep you learning and engaged throughout the quarter.

Brand Audit and Presentation (G)

The final group project for this course is a comprehensive brand audit, where each team will analyze a brand of their choice (pending instructor approval) using frameworks and tools introduced throughout the quarter. The goal is to evaluate the brand's current positioning, identity, equity, and communication strategy, and to develop strategic recommendations for strengthening or evolving the brand. Over the course of the term, student groups will gather and synthesize data from a variety of sources, including the brand's own materials, customer feedback, competitor analysis, and market trends. The final deliverable will be a well-organized report that presents the

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brand's strengths and weaknesses, diagnoses key branding challenges, and proposes actionable insights supported by evidence. In addition to the written report, each group will deliver a 10–12 minute presentation summarizing their audit findings and recommendations, tailored for a professional audience. Creativity, analytical rigor, and visual polish will all be key components of successful projects. This assignment will allow students to apply branding theory to a real-world scenario and practice delivering strategic recommendations in a compelling way. A detailed description of the project, including grading criteria and the evaluation rubric, are posted on Canvas. See the schedule for due dates.

You will submit these assignments through Canvas prior to the start of the last class.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:

<http://senate.ucsd.edu/manual/appendices/appendix2.pdf>

How the Honor Code applies to this course:

Collaboration is a key component of this course. However, there are certain assignments that are to be done independently, with no outside assistance. Any effort to gain an advantage not given to all students is dishonest whether or not the effort is successful. Copying material from case solutions, teaching notes, or other sources on-line undermines your learning and is inappropriate from an ethical standpoint. Your ability to benefit from the learning exercise and my ability to accurately evaluate your performance depends upon your integrity at these times. The UCSD academic community regards academic dishonesty as an extremely serious matter, with serious consequences that range from probation to expulsion. When in doubt about issues regarding plagiarism, paraphrasing, quoting, or collaboration, please consult with me

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or fosorio@ucsd.edu.

AI POLICY FOR MARKETING MANAGEMENT COURSE (written with the help of ChatGPT)

This policy outlines the appropriate use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools in the Marketing Management course, ensuring that the technology enhances learning while preserving the integrity of individual thought and effort. The policy applies to all enrolled students in the Executive MBA Marketing Management course.

Permitted Use of AI:

- o Understanding and Research: Students are permitted to use AI tools to deepen their understanding of course materials and assist with research related to course topics. AI can be utilized to summarize readings, provide explanations of complex concepts, and generate ideas for project brainstorming.

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- o Explicitly Allowed Assignments: AI may be used in completing assignments only when explicitly stated in the assignment instructions. These will be designed to specifically leverage AI capabilities in a way that enhances the learning objectives of the task.

Prohibited Use of AI:

- o General Assignments and Examinations: The use of generative AI is strictly prohibited in the completion of regular assignments and during examinations. Assignments are crafted to assess individual understanding and the ability to apply marketing concepts independently.
- o Discussion Contributions: Participation in course discussions, whether online or in-person, must be free of AI assistance. The value of these discussions lies in the personal insights, original thought, and interaction among peers, which AI usage could undermine.

Rationale:

- o The educational value of assignments and discussions in this course stems from personal intellectual engagement and the development of individual analytical skills. AI, while beneficial in certain contexts, can shortcut these learning processes and reduce the depth of personal understanding and critical thinking.

Enforcement:

- o Students are expected to adhere to this policy as part of their commitment to academic integrity. Violations of the AI usage policy will be subject to review under the standard academic misconduct procedures and could result in disciplinary action.

Support and Clarifications:

- o Students are encouraged to seek clarification from the instructor regarding the use of AI tools in specific instances. The instructor is available to provide guidance on how AI can be appropriately integrated into learning activities without compromising educational outcomes.